Workplace Behaviour – Unit II Assignment Answers

Simple-language version · written in the same style as the Unit I answers · 5 marks each

Q1. Apply the major factors affecting personality to a workplace situation involving employee behaviour.

Meaning in simple words: Personality is a person's fairly steady way of thinking, feeling and behaving. At work it is mainly shaped by three factors: heredity, environment and situation.

Situation: Two equally skilled employees are given the same client presentation. One speaks to the client easily. The other prefers a detailed written presentation.

Factors:

- **Heredity (inborn):** inherited and biological tendencies form part of the base of a person's nature.
- **Environment (upbringing):** family, culture, education and social experience shape attitudes and habits.
- **Situation (the moment):** the current setting can bring out, reduce or change a trait.
- **Interaction:** the behaviour we see is the combined result of the person's tendencies and the present surroundings.

Application: The two employees differ because of their past experience and confidence. Under a supportive leader, the quieter employee may perform very well, which shows the power of the situation.

Managerial use: Avoid stereotyping. Use knowledge of personality to place people in suitable roles, communicate better, coach and form teams, but judge people by their actual behaviour and performance.

Diagram: Heredity + Environment + Situation → Personality → Workplace Behaviour

Conclusion: Personality comes from many factors, so managers should understand it but never judge a person by a label.

Q2. Apply classical conditioning, operant conditioning and social learning principles to a suitable workplace behaviour.

Meaning in simple words: Learning is a fairly lasting change in behaviour that comes from experience. At work, employees learn through three routes.

The three types:

- **Classical conditioning (learning by association):** a neutral signal gets linked with a real response. *Example:* a supervisor's quiet walk-through becomes a signal that makes staff alert.
- **Operant conditioning (learning by consequences):** behaviour is shaped by what follows it.
    - *Positive reinforcement:* a valued reward is added after good behaviour, such as praise or recognition.

    - *Negative reinforcement:* an unpleasant condition is removed after good behaviour, such as less close monitoring after reliable work.
- **Social learning (learning by watching):** people learn by observing a credible model, remembering what they saw, copying it and noticing the result.

Situation: A customer-service manager introduces a new complaint-handling method. An experienced executive demonstrates it while new staff watch (social learning). Staff practise and get immediate praise for correct use (positive reinforcement). After steady performance, close supervision is reduced (negative reinforcement).

Managerial use: State the desired behaviour clearly, provide a good role model, give timely feedback and keep consequences fair and linked to behaviour.

Diagram: Association / Consequence / Observation → Learning → Changed Behaviour

Conclusion: Using all three types of learning helps employees pick up and keep good work behaviour.

Q3. Apply reinforcement principles to a workplace situation involving positive and negative reinforcement.

Meaning in simple words: Reinforcement means strengthening a behaviour so that it is more likely to be repeated. It can be done by adding something pleasant or by removing something unpleasant.

Situation: A sales team lead wants her team to submit daily reports on time.

Positive reinforcement (add something good):

- A valued consequence is added after the desired behaviour.
- *Example:* the lead praises and publicly recognises team members who submit reports on time.

Negative reinforcement (remove something unpleasant):

- An unpleasant condition is removed after the desired behaviour.
- *Example:* employees who submit reliable reports for a month no longer need daily checking by the lead.
- Note: negative reinforcement is *not* punishment. It encourages good behaviour by taking away something disliked.

Result: In both cases employees repeat on-time reporting.

Managerial use:

1. Give the reward soon after the behaviour.
2. Keep the reward fair and meaningful.
3. Reduce close monitoring only after consistent, reliable performance.
4. Do not depend on reinforcement alone; also support overall growth.

Diagram: Desired Behaviour → Pleasant Added (Positive) / Unpleasant Removed (Negative) → Behaviour Repeated

Conclusion: Both kinds of reinforcement strengthen desired behaviour when used fairly and on time.

Q4. Apply the MBTI and Big Five personality models to a workplace situation.

Meaning in simple words: Personality models help managers talk about differences between people. They should support, not replace, direct evidence of how a person actually performs.

Situation: A manager is forming a product-development team and wants to understand members' working styles.

1. MBTI (Myers-Briggs Type Indicator): describes a person's preferred way of working using four pairs: Extraversion–Introversion, Sensing–Intuition, Thinking–Feeling and Judging–Perceiving.

2. Big Five model:

- **Openness:** curiosity and interest in new ideas; useful for creative work.
- **Conscientiousness:** dependability, planning and persistence; linked to reliable task completion.
- **Extraversion:** sociability and assertiveness; may suit interaction-heavy roles, though introverts can also lead well.
- **Agreeableness:** cooperation, trust and concern for others; helpful in teamwork.
- **Emotional stability:** calmness and resilience under pressure (the opposite is neuroticism).

Application: Use the models for self-awareness, communication and team discussion, not as strict selection tools. A balanced team gains from different tendencies, but job needs and ability must also be considered.

Diagram: Personality Model (MBTI / Big Five) → Understand Differences → Better Communication & Team Formation

Conclusion: These models are useful guides to individual differences, but should be used with evidence and fairness.

Q5. A manager's decision about an employee is influenced by a recent incident. Apply the concepts of perception to this situation.

Meaning in simple words: Perception is the way people select, organise and interpret information to understand their surroundings. Because a manager may judge with incomplete information, mistakes can enter appraisals and decisions.

Situation: An employee has worked well for eleven months but makes one visible mistake just before the appraisal.

Perception concepts involved:

- **Recency effect:** recent events get too much weight compared with performance over the whole period.
- **Halo/horns effect:** one strong good or bad quality colours the overall judgement. Here one mistake makes all the work look bad (horns effect).
- **Selective perception:** the evaluator notices what fits their expectation and ignores contrary evidence.
- **Stereotyping:** judging by assumptions about a group, not by facts about the person.
- **Projection:** assuming others are like oneself, or comparing the employee with another person.

Managerial use: Use written records from the full review period, several performance measures, behaviour-based criteria and, where possible, more than one source of information.

Diagram: Incomplete Information → Perceptual Error → Biased Judgement → Unfair Decision

Conclusion: Knowing perceptual errors helps managers take fairer, evidence-based decisions.

Q6. Apply the concept of heredity, environment and situation to personality differences among employees.

Meaning in simple words: Personality is a person's lasting pattern of thinking, feeling and behaving. Employees differ because of three influences.

Situation: In one department, some employees are outgoing and quick to speak up, while others are reserved and careful.

The three influences:

- **Heredity:** inborn, inherited tendencies provide part of the foundation for a person's nature.
- **Environment:** family, culture, education and social experience influence habits and behaviour.
- **Situation:** the immediate setting can strengthen, hide or change how a trait appears. A reserved person may speak up when the team is friendly and supportive.
- **Interaction:** observed behaviour reflects the combined effect of personal tendencies and the present setting.

Managerial use: Do not label employees. Understand why they differ, create a suitable work setting and judge them on actual performance.

Diagram: Heredity + Environment + Situation → Personality Differences → Different Work Behaviour

Conclusion: Differences among employees come from several sources, so managers should deal with each person understandingly.

Q10. A supervisor rates an employee poorly because of a recent mistake. Apply perceptual-error concepts.

Meaning in simple words: Perception is how people select, organise and interpret information to make sense of their environment. Errors in it can make judgements unfair.

Situation: An employee has performed consistently well for eleven months but makes one visible mistake just before the appraisal. The supervisor gives a poor overall rating mainly because of that incident.

Errors involved:

- **Recency effect:** the supervisor gives too much weight to the latest event and too little to the whole year. This is the main error here.
- **Horns effect:** if the supervisor then sees all of the employee's work negatively because of the one mistake, one bad trait is colouring the whole judgement.

- **Selective perception:** the supervisor may notice only information that supports the poor opinion.

Correction:

1. Review records of the entire period.
2. Use clear, behaviour-based rating criteria.
3. Discuss the incident with the employee and hear their side.
4. Take opinions from more than one source where possible.

Diagram: Recent Mistake → Recency / Horns Error → Poor Rating → Unfair Appraisal

Conclusion: Awareness of perceptual errors lets supervisors rate employees on the whole picture, not on one incident.

Q14. Apply the Big Five model to form a balanced project team.

Meaning in simple words: Personality frameworks help managers discuss individual differences, but they should support, not replace, direct evidence about performance.

Situation: A manager is building a product-development team.

Using the Big Five:

- **Conscientious members** for planning and follow-through.
- **Open members** for generating ideas.
- **Agreeable members** for cooperation and teamwork.
- **Emotionally stable members** for handling pressure.
- **Extraverted members** for client contact and communication, while introverts can also lead well.

Caution: Use the model for team discussion and balance, not as a strict selection tool. Skills and job needs must also be checked.

Diagram: Big Five Traits → Complementary Team Roles → Balanced Team → Better Project Results

Conclusion: A mix of traits, matched with skills, helps build a balanced and effective project team.

Q15. Apply the perception concept to improve fairness in performance appraisal.

Meaning in simple words: Perception is the process of selecting, organising and interpreting information. If it is biased, appraisals become unfair.

Situation: An employee has performed well for eleven months but makes one visible mistake just before appraisal. If the supervisor interprets all of the employee's work negatively because of that incident, the recency effect is at work.

Ways to improve fairness:

1. Keep documented records for the full review period.
2. Use several performance indicators, not one event.
3. Use clear, behaviour-based criteria.

4. Collect information from more than one source where possible.
5. Train appraisers about the recency, halo/horns, stereotyping and projection errors.
6. Discuss the rating openly with the employee.

Diagram: Full-period Evidence + Clear Criteria + Multiple Sources → Less Perceptual Error → Fair Appraisal

Conclusion: Understanding perception lets organisations design appraisals that are accurate, consistent and trusted by employees.

Social learning principles applied to train new employees (question number not clear in your notes)

Meaning in simple words: Learning is a fairly lasting change in behaviour that comes from experience. In social learning, people learn by watching others.

Four steps of social learning:

- **Attention:** new staff watch a credible, skilled model.
- **Retention:** they remember what they saw.
- **Reproduction:** they practise and copy the behaviour.
- **Reinforcement:** they see or receive a good result, such as praise.

Situation: A customer-service manager introduces a new complaint-handling method. An experienced executive demonstrates it while new staff observe. The staff then practise the method and receive immediate praise for correct use.

Managerial use: Choose respected role models, give a clear demonstration, allow practice with feedback and reward correct behaviour.

Diagram: Observe Model → Remember → Practise → Praise → Learned Behaviour

Conclusion: Social learning is a quick, practical way to train new employees because they learn from real examples.